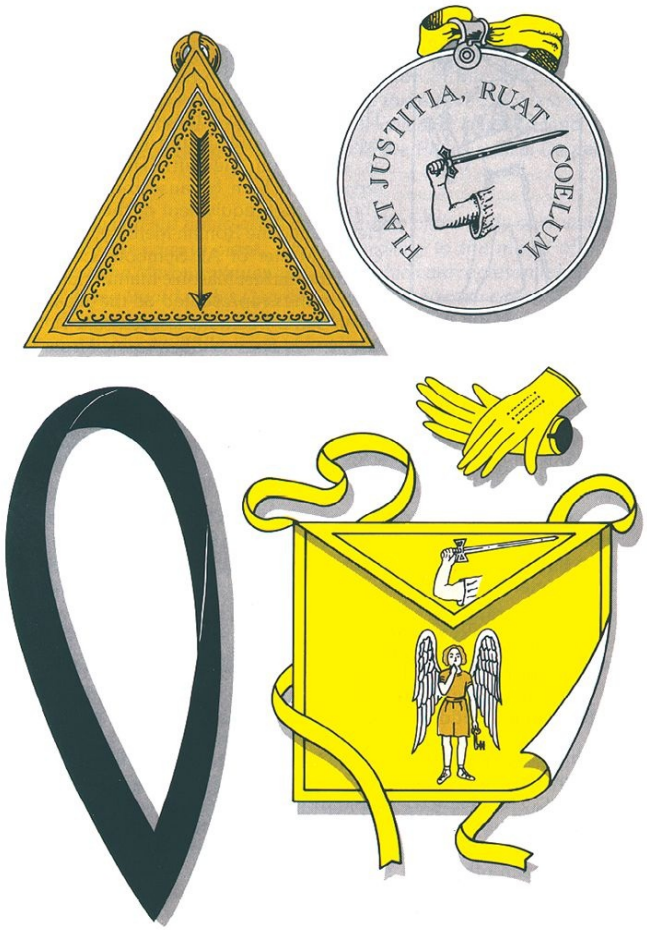
The 21st Degree – Noachite or Prussian Knight



The apron and gloves of this degree are yellow. On the upper part of the apron is an arm, naked and upraised, holding a naked sword. Under it is a human figure, erect, with wings, the forefinger of his right hand on his lips; in his left hand he holds a key. He is the Egyptian figure of silence, called by the Greeks Harpocrates, though the wings are an addition. Plato said that wings symbolized "intelligence." To the alchemists they stood for the higher, active, male principle.

The order is a broad black ribbon, worn from right to left.

The jewel is a silver, full moon, suspended from the third buttonhole of the vest, or a golden triangle traversed by an arrow, point–downward, suspended from the collar. On the jewel is an arm upraised, holding a naked sword, and around it the motto, *Fiat Justitia, Ruat Coelum*, meaning "Let there be Justice, though the Heavens fall." These were the words of William Murray, First Earl of

Mansfield (1704–1793), Lord Chief Justice of England, uttered in the case of Rex vs. Wilkes, June 8, 1768.

DUTIES

Be humble and modest, trusting in God.
Be steadfast and courageous in the face of adversity.

LESSONS

The downfall of evil is certain.
A free and independent judiciary is necessary to human progress.
Journalism should be fair, just and responsible.

FOR REFLECTION

Do you keep the ideal of justice before your own interests?

IMPORTANT SYMBOLS

Masked brothers, full moon, sword of a knight.

This degree was formerly subtitled “the Masonic Key” in Etienne Morin’s Order of the Royal Secret. Prior to Pike’s reworking, it was the object of much controversy. It abandons the Hiramic legend and the building of Solomon’s Temple entirely and, in its earlier workings, was founded operatively on the building of the Tower of Babel. Mackey says of it:

> *... it is misplaced in any series of Degrees supposed to emanate from Solomon’s Temple. It is, as an unfitting link, an unsightly interruption of the chain of legendary symbolism substituting Noah for Solomon and Peleg for Hiram Abif. ... That it was ever adopted into the Masonic system is only to be attributed to the passion for advanced Degrees which prevailed in France in the middle of the eighteenth century* (Vol. II, p. 714).

Recognizing this incongruity, Pike based his ritual on a remarkable German judicial institution of the Middle Ages known as the *Vehmgericht*, or secret tribunal. He may have chosen this institution for several reasons. Pike was a noted and self–taught lawyer who practiced both in Arkansas and New Orleans.

Thus, he had more than a casual interest in the history of law and jurisprudence. Secondly, since this secret tribunal developed in the Middle Ages when knighthood and chivalry flowered, it is more in line chronologically with other Council degrees than the version which based its ceremony on the Noachites (descendants of Noah) and the story of the Tower of Babel. Only a hint of this remains in the present ritual—the recitation to remember the fate of Phaleg, called in the King James Bible "Peleg." Phaleg, along with many other descendants of Noah, began to build a tower whose top may reach into heaven, the Tower of Babel. For this effrontery to God, their speech was confounded and they were scattered over the whole earth (Genesis 11). In the current version of the degree the parallel to the moral lesson of this story is found in the fate of one who acts boldly and with conceit and does not live within God's will.

During its most powerful period, the *Vehmgericht* was a closed court which met only at night and was possessed of extraordinary power. To become a judge in the tribunal, a *Freischoffen*, was an honor and brought privileges with the position. The prospective judge was obliged

> *... to prove he was free born, of a good family, not suspected of any misdeeds, and was in the enjoyment of all his rights; and finally two Freischoffen were obliged to become his security. ... A solemn oath held all the members united and not even in the confessional were they suffered to reveal the secret of the Vehm tribunal; neither were the clergy themselves admitted into it* (Legenda XIX–XXX, p. 11).

In its early years almost all princes, nobles and knights became *Freischoffen.* They possessed a rite of initiation and had both a secret sign and peculiar greeting whereby they recognized each other. Eventually an association of several thousand men from the highest to the lowest classes spread throughout Germany. The members both judged and punished freely, not subject to account for what they did. Punishments were banishment and death by hanging at the tree or post nearest to where the condemned criminal was found; if caught in the commission of a crime, the criminal was hanged without a trial. The

Freischoffen were only required to stick a knife in the ground close to the body as a sign that the sentence of the *Vehmgericht* had been executed. At the end of the 15th century the power and authority of the *Vehmgericht* deteriorated for the reasons mentioned by Pike:

> *Such power placed in human hands without the protecting check of publicity and responsibility could not long exist without misuse. In the great development and extension of the association, it could not be avoided but that unworthy individuals should be received as members who used the power confided to them for the sole satisfaction of their revengeful and baser passions* (Legenda XIX–XXX, pp. 18–19).

CEREMONY

The lodge is styled a Tribunal after the *Vehmgericht* just discussed. The set is simple, requiring only a light representative of the full moon. The Tribunal members all wear black masks. The presiding officer, the Lieutenant Commander, is to be unknown to the members. The nocturnal setting and the masked brothers dramatically represent the secretive nature of the *Vehmgericht* and its members, the *Freischoffen*. The secret Tribunal should remind us that we know not the real character of those who may judge us nor the time of judgment.

The candidate represents Adolf the Saxon, a Knight of the Holy Cross who has just returned from a crusade in Palestine. He appeals to the Tribunal for justice. While he was away, his land was stolen from him with a deed forged by Count Reinfred and the Bishop of Vienna. The Count sits on the Tribunal; he, of course, denies the charges and leaves to procure the deed. When he returns there is an argument that cannot be decided, for each has only his word as evidence. The accuser, Adolph, is not a noble and though not a member of the Tribunal, as is the Count, his word is equally accepted. This is a reminder of how

> *... indispensable to Human Progress is a free and independent judiciary. For it is ... the right of free entrance into the Courts of Justice, where even the*

weakest may prefer his complaint against the most powerful [which] makes a people free (Legenda XXXII, p. 13).

Since the accusation cannot be settled, Adolf demands trial by oath to prove the truth of his accusation. His wish is granted. The trial by oath is given and both adversaries, one at a time, place their right hand upon the cross–shaped hilt of a sword swearing before God the truth of their claims. Since both have done so, Adolf demands trial by ordeal to prove his accusation. Trial by ordeal is an appeal to God; we are reminded He protects the innocent and punishes the guilty. The ordeal chosen by Adolf involves three tests with three brass rods using fire, incense and water. Although such "trials by ordeal" were customary, the Count refuses these as an appeal to sorcery, but it is nonetheless performed. Dissatisfied with the result, Reinfred demands trial by wager of battle, but before such can occur the document is proved a forgery by certain devices.

The Count represents the type not to be emulated; he is most bold, knowing his own guilt, denying it before God and throughout the trial in which it was believed God would judge between guilt and innocence. The Mason is to be the opposite: humble and modest, trusting in God. Though evil may prosper for a time, its downfall is certain. Those under its sway are counseled to have patience and faith.

LECTURE

It is here that we find Pike, a former newspaper editor, advocating responsible, fair and just journalism. In the Legenda for this degree he notes the benefit of the protecting check of publicity (pp. 18–19), demonstrating a clear understanding of the importance of a free press to the preservation of democracy. Further, he charges all men to be modest and humble in their treatment of their fellows and slow to entertain evil thoughts of others or their intentions. He also instructs us to be humble and modest toward the Deity and His great plans.

Be Humble and Modest:

You are especially charged in this Degree to be modest and humble, and not vain–glorious nor filled with self–conceit. Be not wiser in your own opinion than the Deity, nor find fault with His works, nor improve upon what He has done. Be modest also in your intercourse with your fellows, and slow to entertain evil thoughts of them, and reluctant to ascribe to them evil intentions (p. 334).

One ought, in truth, to write or speak against no other one in this world. Each man in it has enough to do, to watch and keep guard over himself (p. 335).

When a Mason hears of any man that hath fallen into public disgrace, he should have a mind to commiserate his mishap, and not to make him more disconsolate. To envenom a name by libels, that already is openly tainted, is to add stripes with an iron rod to one that is flayed with whipping; and to every well–tempered mind will seem most inhuman and unmanly (pp. 335–336).

If we even do know vices in men, we can scarce show ourselves in a nobler virtue than in the charity of concealing them: if that be not flattery persuading to continuance. And it is the basest office man can fall into, to make his tongue the defamer of the worthy man (p. 337).

There is but one rule for the Mason in this matter. If there be virtues, and he is called upon to speak of him who owns them, let him tell them forth impartially. And if there be vices mixed with them, let him be content the world shall know them by some other tongue than his (p. 337).

The Mason should be humble and modest toward the Grand Architect of the Universe, and not impugn His Wisdom, nor set up his own imperfect sense of Right against His Providence and dispensations, nor attempt too rashly to explore the Mysteries of God's Infinite Essence and inscrutable plans, and of the Great Nature which we are not made capable to understand (p. 338).

… *let* [the Mason] *build no Tower of Babel, under the belief that by ascending he will mount so high that God will disappear or be superseded by a great monstrous aggregate of material forces, or mere glittering, logical formulas; but, evermore, standing humbly and reverently upon the earth and looking with awe*

and confidence toward Heaven, let him be satisfied that there is a real God; a person, and not a formula; a Father and protector, who loves, and sympathizes, and compassionates; and that the eternal ways by which He rules the world are infinitely wise, no matter how far they may be above the feeble comprehension and limited vision of man (pp. 338–39).



THE TOWER OF BABEL
by Gustave Dore